

Pathwork Lecture No. 146
An Unedited Lecture
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THE POSITIVE CONCEPT OF LIFE; FEARLESSNESS TO LOVE;
THE BALANCE BETWEEN ACTIVITY AND PASSIVITY

Greetings, my dearest friends. Be blessed every one of you. Blessed be this hour. A positive concept of the universe as a benign force and benign fate for man, the freedom and fearlessness to love, and a healthy balance between activity and passivity -- all these form a comprehensive whole in order for an individual to be in harmony with himself and with life and thus fulfill himself in every possible way. All these three aspects depend on the awakening and activation of man's innermost center, the nucleus that we call the real self.

None of these three facets is possible without the real self being activated. As long as the outer ego is the sole motivator of the individual's life, it is impossible to have confidence in life's benign nature; it is impossible to be fearless about loving; and it is impossible to establish a healthy balance between activity and passivity. Let us look at this more closely. A healthy concept of life means a truthful concept of life. And a truthful concept of life means the knowledge of, the experience of life as being utterly benign. Whenever man is away from the truth, he must experience life as a hostile force, as something to defend himself against. We have seen this again and again on the path you are working on. When you reach the deeper regions of your innermost being, you see that somehow there is always a negative concept of life.

There is direct interaction between your faults, your defects, and a negative concept of life. Always it works both ways. Because you are driven and controlled by the destructive force set in motion by the negative concept of life, you must expand a negative belief, no matter how little you may be aware of this belief. And because of the negative belief, you must be in a defensive position toward life with which you perpetuate the destructive trend.

In the last lecture, I discussed the necessity of transforming the faults and defects of the character. Let us understand precisely what is necessary for this transformation to be possible. Of course, the first step is always awareness of these defects. This is not easy -- and yet, once approached in the proper attitude, it is not difficult at all. Once you are aware of the specific defects, the next step must be to understand the reason for their existence, to understand why you cling to them. When you look objectively and deeply, you will find that in each specific instance a fault or defect is supposed to ward off something that you assume will happen to you. In other words, a negative assumption is taken for granted. Once you see this, the third step can be undertaken, and that is to question the validity of this assumption. Is it true that what you assume actually would happen if you were not to express this particular fault? This question must be precisely posed. The possibility that it might not be so must be seriously considered. At the same time, expand your view of the significance and the effect on others of the fault in question, regardless of whether it is expressed only in thinking and feeling or also in actual behavior. In order to truly and sincerely want to shed a fault, it is essential to comprehend the effect it has on others as

well as the certainty of its protective value, which must become, at least, a strong doubt. When you are no longer so sure that it protects you and possibly even begin to see that you are harmed by it rather than benefited, when you also see the harm it inflicts on others, then and then only will you want to use the energy invested in the fault into a new, constructive attitude that will take the place of the old destructive one. This is the way that transformation must occur. It can rarely, if ever, occur in any other way. It is impossible to transform something that you do not even know exists. It is impossible to transform something when you do not know why you hold on to this attitude, when you ignore its significance, the belief behind it, and its effects. As long as this ignorance, this glossing over, this vagueness exists, transformation cannot happen.

All this is impossible to accomplish without the help of the real self, which must be directly activated and contacted by the ego faculties. Without this help, the necessary energy, the stamina, the momentum are missing so that at all times the ego faculties must establish a connection with the real, inner self so that the enlightenment and the vision necessary will ensue.

A second aspect under discussion is fearlessness to love. Any one of my friends working on this path sooner or later, at one point or another, has seen that there is a fear of loving behind most predicaments and conflicts. This may take different forms with different people; and even with the same person, it may appear under a different guise in various expressions in his life.

The whole world has generally been aware of the importance of love since time immemorial. All truth teachings postulate that love means freedom, peace, life. Nonlove means enslavement, conflict, death. It creates restlessness, anxiety, and unhappiness. With all important spiritual teachings, including modern science in the form of psychology and psychiatry, agreeing on this fact, why does man nevertheless find it so hard to give himself wholeheartedly and fearlessly to the stream that comes from deep within himself? The natural mold of existence is a state of love. But man manages to cover it up and contort it into many unnatural and laborious forms of existence. All these twists and quirks alienate man from that center where love is a natural fact, an effortless fact that flows as gracefully as any natural phenomenon does.

When man hinders this flow, it can only be because he fears it. There are many definitions of love, and man gropes for these definitions in the assumption that he has to define it in his mind and understand it with his intellect in order to make love come into his soul from the outside. This again is a tortuous, twisted, and erroneous approach, for you do not need a concept in your intellect, you do not need a definition, and you certainly cannot produce love as a factor from outside. Love exists in perfect form within yourself.

The only definition at all useful is to know that anything that furthers unity, inclusion, expansion, union, anything that realizes the benign nature of the universe is love and perpetuates love. Anything that ignores the divine and benign nature of the universe and of life and therefore moves in a direction of exclusion and separateness is the opposite of love and must perpetuate the opposite of love. The opposite of love is nonlife -- various degrees of death, for there are many degrees of death, just as there are many degrees of life. It perpetuates fear. Yet man fears the life, the peace, and the freedom of love, and clings to the separating forces in himself of nonlove as a saving, protecting device. It is and has become of increasing urgency to comprehend this, for the majority of my friends who find themselves successfully working on their path of self-realization lately have come or in the near future are about to come to that area within themselves where they

encounter something they may have totally ignored until now. They may have deluded themselves that they have love, or they may have vaguely known an inner refusal to love but never quite faced or really understood this to be a fact about themselves. This is hardly ever an overall fact applying to the total personality, except with the insane. But the average person has many areas where he does love and is unafraid to do so. Where the problems exist in the inner and outer life, it will become apparent that they are due to the refusal to love in certain respects connected with the specific problems. When this recognition takes place, it is often useful to compare one's attitude of refusing to love with those areas where one does love. The analysis and comparison of both attitudes with the results in outer life, as well, will reveal how false the fear to love is and how safe and secure and beneficial it is to love. The areas in you where you discover a determination not to love will also disclose, upon closer inspection, that coupled with the resistance, or rather causing it, is a fear to love. The realization of this is of crucial importance, which must not under any circumstances be glossed over or neglected in your self-confrontation. It is necessary that you put precisely into words, "Here, in this or that respect, I do not love, and I refrain from wanting to love because I am afraid of it." At this point, you still do not know why this is. You may feel consternation. You may be puzzled. You ask yourself, "What do I fear?" There may come some answers which might be partly valid; partly they may be a glib theoretical explanation which may or may not strike you as a cliché. Perhaps the answer presents itself that you are more vulnerable to hurt when you love. And yet when you say this, it is not really convincing. When you think deeply and honestly, you will have to admit that this is not true at all. A certain answer you might come across may be that you indulge in vindictiveness, in striking out at others and at life as a whole. This is perhaps a little closer to the point you need to find, which also needs to be fully recognized, accepted, and understood. But it is still not the whole story.

The whole story lies in the third facet of the discussion of this lecture. Before turning to it, I want to say, just as transformation from a negative to a positive attitude, concept, or characteristic is impossible to execute exclusively with the ego, without eliciting the faculties of the real self, this is even more true when it comes to loving. For love is not a quality that resides in the ego. The ego has other functions. It has functions of will, discrimination, and action. But it does not possess the faculty of love. The faculty of love is a process of feeling which comes totally from the inner being. This is why love cannot be intellectualized, conceptualized, and understood in terms of intellectual processes, as many people attempt to do. It is a feeling that must be permitted. To give the self this full permission to love includes not only the realization of the inner being but also a positive conception of life and the universe. For if it were the truth that life is hostile and depriving for man, then love, indeed, would be a dangerous facet. However, if it is true that life is benign, liberating, and giving to man, if it is for rather than against man, love is not only not dangerous, it is the only way possible to exist in peace and harmony with the existing factors of the universe. So it is absolutely necessary, my friends, that you connect the fear to love with your negative conception and expectation of life, on the one side, and the freedom from fear to love with a positive, benign concept and expectation of life on the other. It will be interesting to observe how one and the same person can in certain areas of life be in total harmony with reality and thus have abiding trust in life, with the result that his ability to feel love is well developed. The further consequences of favorable experience in these areas are inevitable but seldom give rise to examining this fact and comparing it with the unhappy areas of life experience, where the exact opposite holds true. This direct interaction and causal connection must be brought into awareness and should be observed as much as possible.

Only by trying out, literally by testing it, can you convince yourself of the positive nature of life. Then you will abandon seclusion, separateness, hate, and fear, which all comprise nonlove. Open yourself up, tentatively at least, to try the benign nature of life and therefore of man, for both must be the same.

This brings us to the third aspect in this triad, which is a healthy balance between activity and passivity. A long time ago, almost at the very beginning of these lectures, I spoke about active and passive forces in the universe. Although I stated then a number of valid factors regarding this topic, it was not possible at that time to go as deeply, nor was it possible to establish the connections with other facets of man's inner life as we can now.

Many of my friends have encountered in the course of their self-search a strange and inexplicable distaste for activity and an equally strange and inexplicable hankering for nonaction. Some find this to be stronger than others, but in whatever form or to whatever degree it appears, it is necessary to comprehend this aspect of the human psyche. This hankering for passivity means that the person feels passivity is a desirable state. It seems to promise the state of peace man unconsciously confuses with the state of being, while the state of activity represents a chore, a difficulty you fear you cannot live up to and therefore wish to avoid. Why is this so, my friends?

First of all, it is important to understand that this is a distortion and misunderstanding of duality. It is confusing fragmentary aspects of the unitive state and separating them from their complementary fragments. In the dualistic mode of experiencing life, activity and passivity appear as opposites. In the reality of the highest state of consciousness -- the state of being -- both activity and passivity intermingle. It is equally true to say that the healthy state of activity is also passive, while the healthy state of passivity is also active. Only on the dualistic level does this appear to be a contradiction. The way this can best be demonstrated in terms of your immediate everyday life is by reminding you that every healthy activity you undertake is relaxed, easy, effortless, which seems to connote passive qualities. In this relaxation, the outgoing movement of action is unstrained and contains a rhythm of peace, if I may put it in these words. This rhythm of peace, if it is fragmentized, if it is experienced as a particle and not as a whole, may seem as passivity. By the same token, we can approach it from the other end, from the other facet of this unity of forces. When you feel yourself in a healthy passive state, it is never a static state, which is motionless. I know I have said this in the past in different connections, but it must be repeated here to make the underlying significance of this lecture clear. In healthy passivity, or in the state of being, the action of movement exists -- the rhythm of the universe, the motion of peace that is unstrained.

The active/passive balance principle must reign in every creative process in the universe. There cannot be a creative process thinkable without the active and passive forces harmonizing and complementing and furthering one another. This applies to every healthy and purposeful activity in your life, on the plane of existence in which you function. This applies to the more crass manifestations of this principle, such as the balance between work and leisure. But each of these facets contains both active and passive principles. For work coming forth from a healthy organism flows effortlessly, while leisure could not possibly be invigorating and revitalizing if it were static, that is, without movement. If it were that, it would be death, and death does not invigorate. Only life does. And life must be movement, as I have said so many times.

In distortion and duality, activity and passivity seem opposites, as I have just said. Hence, one appears as movement, the other as nonmovement. One appears to exert strain; the other promises relief from strain. In other words, we return to the basic duality of good versus bad. One facet seems good, desirable; the other bad, undesirable.

Activity is often experienced as undesirable because it requires a goal direction, a sense of responsibility. It requires the selfhood of the mature personality who copes with his own limitations and the limitations of life as it unfolds itself for him in such a way that these limitations gradually eliminate themselves. If man is totally identified with his ego, action must be frightening because the ego is not equipped to undertake purposeful action without being motivated, carried, and guided by the real self. It simply does not have the requirements at its disposal. So when man, no matter how much lip service he may pay to the existence of the real self, is not in contact with it, when he blocks its immediate manifestations, he must fear activity with all the demands it makes on the individual. The state of nonactivity, or the static state, then seems desirable because it does not make any demands, it does not hold any expectations or obligations man fears to face.

It is equally true to state that when man identifies exclusively with his ego and avoids or neglects the existence of a more universal part in himself, he is often equally afraid of passivity. For the passive state then implies helplessness. The passive state must imply helplessness when, on the other side of the coin, activity is rejected, feared, and avoided. For then helplessness is a natural sequence, a direct result. If you do not act purposefully in the best interest of the universal laws within yourself, you do become helpless; you do become a prey to circumstances beyond your control. Consequently, man often finds himself in the position that, on one level, he avoids activity in the fear that he may not be capable of fulfilling its requirements. On another level, he fears equally the passive state (even the healthy version of it because it is all confused) so that he then becomes overactive as a compensation and on an alienated level, not where it is originally indicated.

With these ideas I present to you, my friends, you may see a very important connection between them and the negative concept of life, which also implies that of your innermost self since these two must be identical. If you suspect and fear the nature of your innermost self, how can you want to establish contact with it? The only salvation and solution then seems to be to concentrate all energies and forces on your outer ego self so that you become more and more disconnected from the innermost being and its life-giving powers. Thereupon you proceed to force yourself into a loving state, partially because you have learned that this is the thing to do and you want to comply with the regulations of society and the world around you; partially to comply with the requirements of your innermost conscience, which can never be completely squelched; and last but not least, in order to succeed in certain aims, like gaining affection, love, approval, respect, acceptance without which it is not possible to live. So you force yourself to love with your ego self, which of course is doomed to fail. As I have said before, the ego cannot possibly give you these powers. It cannot give what it does not possess. Wherever you have genuine love currents, they come from your innermost being whether or not you admit it into existence on a conscious level. Hence, these currents come into your personality almost by the back door, as it were. But when this is impossible because the door is too tightly locked, you cut yourself off from the invigoration of the life stream of love, with increasing feelings of emptiness, helplessness, despair, and isolation. You then try to counteract these feelings with a laborious effort of trying to love with your ego. These efforts exhaust you, and the more exhausted you are, the more must you shrink from activity, which seems an added strain to the exhaustion. You then flee into passivity which seems like relief and

consequently becomes the desirable state, which yet never fulfills you, always leaves you empty, dissatisfied, and increasingly frightened as all false solutions do. The more this way is sought, the greater the apathy becomes, for, naturally, at this point healthy passivity has converted into its distorted form -- apathy. There is little invigorating life movement and action left in it. Anyone who has tasted such a state knows that the static lifelessness of apathy contains a much greater terror than any live hurt, pain, unhappiness could ever be.

You see, my friends, that only when the real self is contacted and allowed into action, regardless of how doubtful you may be or how resistant or how frightened you may be of this possibility, this is the central point that must be worked upon to consolidate all difficulties into one simple, unifying inner movement. Without this, it is not possible to find the abundance and wide open expansion of life that is originally and essentially available to you and in which you can expand and move without threat and find your own reality of being. Without this activation of the real self, love cannot be possible, so that forever and forever you are not only isolated and distrustful, but your conscience cannot ever give you rest. Even if nonlove is only minute in you, as compared with the vast aspects of your personality in which you do love, your conscience still will not let you rest. This may take all sorts of forms of destroying your best interests.

When you do not identify and establish contact with the inner real self, activity cannot be peaceful, and passivity cannot be regenerating. Activity and passivity cannot meld as one unit so that your reactions in life become meaningful and relaxed, and action in itself becomes something desirable. By the same token, passivity will hold no threat of helplessness since you trust yourself and life. All this rests upon your activation -- deliberate, precise and direct -- out of the center of your innermost being.

An important key for this purpose is the following. So often my friends say, "Oh yes, if only I could, but I am not yet capable of wanting to," and they then proceed to wait for a miracle to happen, either from within or without, so that they will suddenly want to act constructively -- in this instance, the expressed intent to activate a universal center within. They wait as though something other than their own immediately available self will propel them. But this can never be. You could wait for ever and ever until the moment when you say, "I will do it, I want to, I will try to," regardless of resistance, doubt, or fear. You will explore the possibility of finding this nucleus of power, intelligence, feeling, and harmony by giving it every chance, if you commit yourself to this possibility, even if at this moment it is but a possibility. How else can it become a factually experienced reality? It cannot do this by theory or by anything that happens from outside or inside, other than by your making it possible to happen. With this approach, you will make it possible, even if only tentatively to begin with so that it will gradually reveal its reality to you. This action on your part must be your commitment to it.

Are there any questions regarding this topic?

QUESTION: Is the life center one commits oneself to located in the subtle bodies, or is it in the physical organs or structure? Or where is it?

ANSWER: It is in all of them. It is life itself which transcends everything where it can find an opening. It cannot be, by its own nature, more in one and less in the other, for it is actually not in a geographically locatable spot. In man's illusory vision regarding time, space, and movement, it

seems as though it is located deep within the solar plexus. This is not an illusion in the sense that this is actually where it manifests most noticeably, but this is so only because this is where man is most receptive, most vulnerable, and most open. It actually flows through every layer of man's organism, of the organization that constitutes the total entity. This, of course, is provided that it is both activated and unobstructed by the organism. To the extent that it is not activated, it cannot reach the outer layers of man's personality. In physical sickness, the body has remained inactivated for some time in the areas of the illness due to corresponding mental and emotional blocks, distortions, and misconceptions.

When man is sick in his outlook, in his attitudes, and therefore in his life experience and life manifestation, it is in those psychic areas that the real self is blocked off and its emanations cannot penetrate. There one can say that it does not reach the outer personality levels, and it is correct to state it is found only in the depth of the spiritual subtle body. This is why, years ago, when my friends started on this path, I said that man must first penetrate the mask self that hides his destructive attitudes. He is so afraid to do so because he thinks this destructive self is the last reality of his person and the only good exists in the facade. Only when this first battle is won can the destructive currents be let out so that they can reconvert into their original form of the hidden real self, which then begins to become manifest. This is the only way the real self can become a reality. It can then surge through the outer personality levels and heal the distortions. A totally self-realized person will be enlivened by the real self on all levels, the physical not less than the emotional and mental ones.

QUESTION: I have reached the point where I meditate to activate the real self in order to get love to come through, having found my misconception about spirituality and the physical body. But it is still dead. I have not been able to activate it.

ANSWER: This is quite natural, my friend. Do not forget how deeply indoctrinated this fear is in you. How many years, already in this lifetime, not to speak of any others, have you conditioned yourself to a pattern of reaction to an orientation and a way to operate, which cannot be broken suddenly? This is even more so than you are aware of. You have just recently reached the first inklings of this fact, which is a tremendous victory on your path. Little by little, you will proceed to realize how much deeper this fear is ingrained in you. You will become aware of more specific reasons for this fear as well as of the same reasons that you already know but have experienced on a deeper level of yourself. As you do so, little by little, the heavy wall, the thick fogs, the mazes of confusion that covered the real self with its strong, wonderful feelings will dissolve. You have already gained some preliminary insight into this fear, but this insight will increase as you observe your reactions when you utter the wish to feel love in your whole person, also your physical body.

QUESTION: You relate death with a lack of love. How can you then explain physical death?

ANSWER: The manifestation of physical death in this sphere of human existence is precisely the result of duality. Duality is a result of erroneous concepts. Error means, in the last analysis, to return to the topic of this lecture, a misunderstanding of life and of the universe. Therefore the individual believes life to be dangerous, hostile, a force against which he must defend himself. This defense must exclude all attitudes of openness, inclusion, movement toward the other -- that is, love. When this movement is lacking, stagnation, stasis, nonlife ensue -- that is, death.

Error equates with nonlove. Nonlove is directly opposed to life as it really is, in its potential, in its waiting readiness to unfold whenever it is allowed to do so because appropriate and truthful concepts do not block the way. This life is a continuum, an eternally moving process, which can be sensed only when the personal psyche follows his moving process. This is a mathematical equation.

QUESTION: I can see that, but I know that I am destined to die even if I am able to love.

ANSWER: No, these are degrees. Man is an interim stage of evolution. The entity does not come from a total state of nonlove, in which there is a very small amount of life -- let us say inorganic life would be most close to a state of life with no love -- to total love, where there is no longer any split, any division, any false concept, where the universal consciousness is totally realized. Hence, where there is no duality, consequently there is no life versus death. These are very slow stages of evolution.

QUESTION: In my work on the path, I found out that I never loved anything or anyone, my only way of loving is neurotic. Listening to your lecture, I am interested to find my real self in this respect. Can you give me some help?

ANSWER: I would advise you to ask yourself specifically to what extent you believe that life is against you, so that you do not dare to love. Put this down in very specific ideas you have. In what particular respects do you assume that life is against you.

QUESTION: In all ways.

ANSWER: Nevertheless, it does not suffice that this be admitted so generally, for this is not quite accurate either. It has to be made specific. After this is done and you look at the written statements, then begin to wonder. Ask yourself, "Maybe I am mistaken, maybe it is not that way." You have to make allowances for the fact that you may be mistaken. So often man remains in a bottleneck on his path because he does not move away from the wrong conclusion. He has found it, he knows in principle that it is wrong, but he remains with it under the guise, "This is the way I feel," waiting to feel different without any effort on his part. But this can come only when he seriously questions his conclusions, and he admits that it can be different, and he looks at this eventuality. The challenge of an assumption must take place after the assumption is put into precise words, "I expect life to be in this or that way, at least as far as I am concerned." Then you make room for truth that could never enter into the closed chambers of your dark, dismal misconceptions about life and your own innermost nature.

QUESTION: We have all lost a friend recently who was very close to this work. I wonder whether we could be in touch with him somehow?

ANSWER: The important thing is not being in touch with any specific individual in the nonphysical world, but that all beings, wherever they are, are in touch with that center of the innermost self that is universal. Everything else falls into place and unifies those who reach out in love. To establish contact that way is not necessary, nor really helpful, for anyone concerned. It shifts the emphasis from that which is important to that which is really unimportant. I know that some people may be disappointed with such an answer and may erroneously believe that this is a rebuff or a lack of concern. This attitude seems denying because the concept they still have about

life and the self is not yet geared to a universal understanding. Eventually they will see that there is really more truth and more love in putting the emphasis on all that furthers the contact with the one and only thing that matters -- self-realization. Then love between individuals happens healthily and naturally in the best possible way. Contact with people who are no longer in the body cannot be a really fulfilling venture, ever. It must lead in some fashion to escape from the very emphasis that is so important. It is often sought to alleviate doubt and pain, but it never really does so in a genuine and lasting way.

QUESTION: But wouldn't it give strength to the deceased person, to be in contact?

ANSWER: No, no. Anyone who is oriented toward striving and growth will have all the contact necessary in his own world. The same laws exist there as here. When you do not want to reach out beyond your limitations and erroneous concepts, no one in the world can help you. You know this perfectly well. But the moment you do, help comes from all sides. Why should this be different in another dimension of consciousness? Love gives strength, and this can be extended and expanded no matter where individuals are. For that, a manifest contact is not necessary.

May the love and the strength and the truth expand in you, in your own innermost being. To the degree that you let this happen, you will be susceptible to the love and the strength and the truth that comes from others to you, that is in the air around you, in the air you breathe. Your gaze will change. Your realizations and perceptions will change to the degree that the love and the strength and the truth from your innermost being unite with those of others. Be in peace. Be in truth. Be in yourself!

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